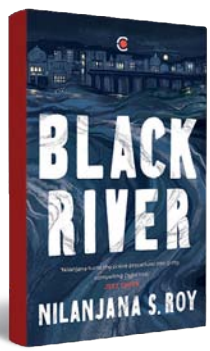
Anatomy of a Crime

Nilanjana Roy's new book is more than a crime saga—it pushes readers to know the characters intimately and without judgement

BLACK RIVER
by Nilanjana Roy
CONTEXT
₹799; 330
pages





HARDIK CHHABRA

Nilanjana Roy's latest novel, *Black River* (released recently by Context), begins with the grisly death of eight-year-old Munia, who is found hanging from a tree in the (fictional) Teetarpur, a village on the Delhi-Haryana border. After a gripping first act, however, the novel presses pause on the actual murder investigation. Instead, across *Black River's* midsection, readers are shown the lives of Chand, his Bengali friend Khalid and his wife, the formidable Rabia, all of whom have left their respective villages to come to Delhi's doorstep.

During an interview, Roy spoke about the novel's structure. "You're pausing what's seemingly a murder mystery in chapter four and you're saying, 'Please trust me while you get to know these people, because it's really important'." This is a bold gambit, but it works wonders for *Black River*, a novel that confidently incorporates several different kinds of voices: some sections are heavily steeped in noir, others borrow from newspaper headlines, while the Chand-Khalid-Rabia sections often read like a contemporary, self-aware eco-fable. Khalid, in particular, having lived all his life on the river bank back home in Bengal, insists that he needs to live near a river; in this novel, the Yamuna is called 'Kalindi'.

"I think I saw, through reading Scottish and Scandinavian crime writers and, indeed, some of our own crime and noir writers in Hindi and Bangla, that you can smuggle a lot into a novel that's ostensibly about crime or murder or whatever," Roy said. "You can smuggle in the portrait of a city or the portrait of a changing time. And sometimes it's more effective because a murder is a violent disruption, it sends a kind of reverberation around a living community. In that moment of grief, confusion, anger and vengeance, you can also maybe see something larger."

Black River's quest for the larger picture takes the novel to some surprising places, but Roy never sacrifices depth of characterisation for narrative momentum. Just about every character on display here, from Chand and Khalid in the past to Ombir Singh (the cop investigating Munia's murder) in the present, displays some moral shortcomings, to varying degrees. Just about every character's fate is affected by the novel's overarching themes—class, patriarchy, violence against women, Delhi's berserk and untrammelled urbanisation-expansion project. They are not really written as heroes or villains; they are regular people reacting to whatever life throws at them, and sometimes, those reactions are informed by conditioning, not reason. By the end of Roy's book, we understand the characters' decisions and their motivations intimately, as though we have known them all our lives.

"I think when you start to write characters that come from backgrounds and experiences that are very different from your own, you can either make those differences a wall or you can take a deep breath and look for what connects you," Roy says. "I come from places of immense security and privilege, so automatically, my experience of the city is very different from Chand's or Rabia's; I have never had to fight for my place. And yet, there is something about this love that holds us here. This is what we have in common: when we came here, we never knew we were going to settle. One year becomes 30, you know?"

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Roy intends to write more ostensibly-crime novels in the years ahead, and on the evidence of *Black River*, that feels like a delicious prospect. ■

Aditya Mani Jha